# Chapter 20 – The Salt March and Independence

"Peace is not a relationship of nations. It is a condition of mind brought about by a serenity of soul. Peace is not merely the absence of war. It is also a state of mind. Lasting peace can come only to peaceful people."

(Jawaharlal Nehru)

While Mohandas Gandhi worked to cultivate a peaceful revolution, his compatriot, Jawaharlal Nehru, followed a similar path. Born in 1889 in Ahallabad, British India, Nehru went to Trinity College, Cambridge, and earned a degree in natural science. Following graduation, he moved to London and studied law at Inner Temple before returning to India to become a practicing lawyer.

It wasn't until Indians under British rule started protesting openly in the 1910s that Nehru joined politics—and it all started with his attendance of the annual Indian National Congress in 1912. A political party comprised mostly of moderates, Congress seemed disturbingly elite to Nehru. He immediately noticed that its members were all English speaking, mostly members of wealthy families. Despite misgivings based on these observations, Nehru decided to go ahead and work with the party in pursuit of Indian civil rights.

In 1930, Nehru joined tens of thousands of other Indians in following Gandhi's plan for disruptive civil disobedience against the British government. Mohandas reasoned that the salt tax, which had been in place since 1882 and required all Indians to buy high-priced salt only from the British, offered the perfect opportunity for a mass demonstration. It was illegal to gather salt, so the protestors decided to walk to the coastal town of Dandi on the Arabian Sea and do just that. Dandi was 386 kilometers (240 miles) away from their starting point in Sabermanti.

The journey began with only a few dozen participants on March 12th, but as they moved westward, many more joined them along the way. Gandhi spoke to the people of each community they marched through, urging his fellow Indians to join him in breaking the law to prove to Great Britain that there was strength within India to think for itself and throw off the chains of colonial oppression. The newspapers reported on this progress, at first